

Poor Communication May Be Slowing Down Your Team

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As more and more employees are working remotely or in hybrid work environments, the need for effective communication has become even stronger.

According to a recent report by FlexOS, employees gave their managers a mediocre seven out of 10 — in other words, a C — on effectively managing hybrid and remote teams. Worse, 30% said they're frustrated by unclear communication from their bosses. Some of these challenges certainly come from the more siloed communication environment created by remote and hybrid work. According to a survey by Fishbowl, just half of all professionals even understand their company's hybrid work plan.

As a manager, it's your job to make sure vital information is shared appropriately and clearly, leaving no room for misunderstandings or conflict. So how can you become an excellent communicator in this ever-changing work environment?

Improve Your Communication

Picture this: you're immersed in a project, and an email from your manager pops up stating, "Let's focus on making it visually appealing." Energized, you dive into graphic design, carefully selecting fonts, colors, and layouts to create an engaging experience for the end-user. Just as you're putting the finishing touches on your visual masterpiece, feeling proud of what you've achieved, a second email appears, bluntly stating, "Please make sure the content is our priority." So what do you do now? Were there edits that were needed on the content? The absence of clear managerial guidance leaves you wading through a quagmire of confusion, affecting not just your productivity but also your morale.

When managers are unclear in their communication, it can rob teams of their focus, diluting the overall quality of their output. It's important for managers to realize that clear, consistent communication isn't an option; it's imperative. Poor communication impedes both individual and collective progress.

Here are a few techniques you can use to improve your communication:

Set expectations up front.

One of the challenges that can come with communicating remotely is actually information overload. We're all constantly getting bombarded with emails, Slacks, phone calls, and the like. It's important to align with your team on the optimal use of these various communication platforms. For example, while email may be suited for formal correspondence and long-term directives, instant messaging apps like MS Teams or Slack can handle immediate needs and quick clarifications.

Being aligned as a team on which tool to use and when can significantly reduce communication friction. It's important for you to consistently stick to the standards you set and remind others if they slip up.

[Poor Communication May Be Slowing Down Your Team \(hbr.org\)](https://hbr.org/2023/10/poor-communication-may-be-slowing-down-your-team)

Consider creating a “clarity canvas.”

When starting a new project together as a team, create a set of documents that succinctly outline project goals, individual responsibilities, process instructions, and key deadlines. This centralized hub, which I call a “clarity canvas,” affords seamless access to the same reservoir of information and can serve as a touchstone for everyone, averting confusion and minimizing back-and-forths.

It’s important to create these documents together — convene all team members, either in person or virtually, and work through each one to ensure you’re all on the same page. Through this alignment, not only are comprehension gaps addressed in real-time during the canvas creation phase, but a robust foundation is also laid for process adherence and knowledge dissemination.

Make everything accessible.

Making sure every team member — remote or in-office — can easily access all communications is non-negotiable. Keep meticulous records of decisions made, meeting minutes, and project statuses in a centralized digital location accessible to all.

Set standards around where documents are stored and how information is saved. If your organization has access to multiple cloud storage platforms, set rules around what gets uploaded and where. It can also be helpful to provide guidelines around sharing settings to make sure everyone who may need to access the information can find it easily.

Establish office hours.

One way to facilitate direct communication with your employees is by setting aside official “office hours” every week — both remotely and in-office. This is time where you should be readily accessible via chat, phone, or video call to discuss any concerns or questions. Consider it a virtual open door, so that both in-office and remote employees have equal opportunity for face time. There’s no need for a specific agenda during this period, just focus on listening empathetically to your staff and addressing their needs. Be fully present. This will make it easier to foster connections with your direct reports.

Do regular debriefs.

After important company announcements, it can be valuable to set up debrief meetings with your team. Doing so will help you evaluate how well your people understand and accept the announcements, and will give you the opportunity to clarify and address any questions. Remember, your team is looking to you to assess how to respond to top-level announcements. You are the mediator of the C-suite’s messages to your team.

Bring everyone together: A team that plays together stays together. Organizing monthly team-building activities can forge stronger bonds and create a more cohesive team culture. While in-person activities often yield higher emotional engagement, virtual events can also be effective, especially for entirely remote teams. Incorporating these organized interactions serves as a catalyst for open communication by breaking down hierarchical or interpersonal barriers and nurturing an environment where ideas can flow freely among team members. This fosters a culture of transparency and trust, which are foundational for effective communication within a team.

Check in periodically: It's not wise to assume that no news is good news. One way to check in with your team is to conduct anonymous surveys every month to gauge what activities are resonating with them. Here are some sample questions, tailored to gauge the resonance of activities, measure the effectiveness of implemented plans, and nurture an open communication culture:

- Which aspects of the recent communication and collaboration activities did you find most beneficial? Please explain.
- Is there any communication or collaboration activity that you feel didn't resonate well with you? What suggestions do you have for improvements?
- What steps can be taken to improve the openness and effectiveness of communication and collaboration within our team?
- Have the recent changes in [specific process or activity] helped in improving your work experience? Please provide examples.
- On a scale of 1 to 10, how would you rate the effectiveness of the team's communication and collaboration?

Follow this up with a team discussion to interpret the survey results, aiming to balance varied preferences. Once the plan is in motion, don't forget to measure its effectiveness and encourage feedback. Fine-tune the approach each quarter, keeping it ever responsive to the team's evolving needs. The ensuing discussions from these check-ins and feedback loops can not only give team members a platform to articulate their preferences and concerns, but also foster a culture of open communication. This procedural transparency in addressing and iterating upon the team's needs and preferences demonstrates a proactive communication culture, indispensable for nurturing a resilient and adaptive team.

Communication is not just a soft skill; it's the linchpin of effective management. As you go through this process, don't shy away from leveraging new technologies that can bring your team closer together, both emotionally and operationally. As a new manager, you have the opportunity to reset old ways and establish a more effective role as a communicator in this hybrid and remote landscape.

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